of at least 40, explaining its short but effective title. At the film's trailer launch in Mumbai, Johar described the action film as "a manic bloodbath" and also "an ambitious one" given that it is perched on the shoulders of a newcomer, Lakshya. "I've heard a lot [on nepotism] and endured for so many years," he said at the launch. "I felt we must take this leap because we'd love it if the industry got one potential movie star."

With *Kill*, Johar and Monga want audiences to know there's art in mayhem too. Citing films like *Train to Busan* and the John Wick series, which have elevated action as a genre, Johar said the attempt wasn't to endorse violence but to "show India a choreographed action film... that action is nothing short of a form of art". Writer-director Nikhil Nagesh Bhat called on the expertise of ace stunts director, SeaYoung Oh (*Snowpiercer*, *War*) to infuse vigour into his script, one that already detailed a lot of the action. The aim, Bhat told Monga, was to "make an emotional action film". Unlike the visual effects-heavy *Kalki 2898 AD*, the biggest effects deployed in *Kill* are the 150 litres of fake blood to evoke reaction to the action.

FLYING SOLO

Where *Kill* rests on the shoulder of a young actor, *Sarfira* (July 12) has the industry's most prolific actor Akshay Kumar stepping into the big shoes of Suriya, the actor who won a National Award for the role in the Tamil original *Soorarai Pottru*. Inspired by the life of Captain G.R. Gopinath who started the low-cost airline Air Deccan against all odds, *Sarfira* is directed by Sudha Kongara, who also directed the Tamil original (she also won a National Award for its script). "*Soorarai Pottru* reached a large audience thanks to OTT platforms, but I always wanted to see it on the big screen, and making it in Hindi was the opportunity for it," says Kongara, even though comparisons with the original, which won five National Awards, are inevitable. "I hope *Sarfira* is an anthem for the youth," she told *India Today*.

Sarfira comes with a change in geographical setting, from Tamil Nadu to Maharashtra. "I believe each film will have something unique to offer because of the talent involved and the varied cultural milieu," says Kongara. "We have also given special importance to the entrepreneurial journey and dreamers' spirit in the remake." It remains to be seen whether *Sarfira* becomes the film that turns around what's been a fraught year or so for Kumar with his films failing to take off at the box office. For Kongara, though, there was no better fit than him to be the inspiring hero. "He takes it in a different direction with a different emotional sensibility, a different individuality," she says.



THE MONSOON SLATE IS DIVERSE BUT NO FILM IS LIKELY TO BE BIGGER IN 2024 THAN KALKI 2898 AD, THE DYSTOPIAN SCI-FI ACTION DRAMA BUDGETED AT AN ESTIMATED RS 600 CRORE

BLAST FROM THE PAST

Kumar's *Sarfira*, though, will have to contend with the Kamal Haasan-starrer *Hindustani: Zero Tolerance* (July 12), which marks the return of freedom fighter-turned-vigilante Senapati (Haasan) after 28 years. Directed by Shankar, the sequel will see the angry old hero launch an intense battle against corruption yet again, although this time in the social media era. During an interaction with the media in Mumbai, Haasan, who has forayed into politics in the past few years, said voting is the best way to act against corrupt politicians. "Films like ours are just reminders of how corrupt we have become," he said. "Everything will change only with collective conscience." Haasan spent three-four hours in the make-up chair to play the rebel with a cause, who defies age when it comes to performing stunts. "He has zero tolerance for those not committed to their art," said actor Siddharth, who is working with the veteran actor for the first time.

For Shankar, revisiting the 1996 film was always at the back of his mind until he cracked the idea after 2.0 (2018). "It took a lot of time to decide what not to do," he says. The original was set in one state, but the scale gets bigger in part II with an event that has ripples across the country and which necessitated Shankar breaking the film in two parts. With production having started before the COVID-19 pandemic and after much delay, some necessitated by on-set accidents, the film finally arrives in cinemas with the expectation that it becomes a pan-India phenomenon, much like the makers of *Kalki 2898 AD* are aiming for.

SMALL SURPRISES

If 2024 has proved anything so far, it's that success can come from the least expected titles. A spate of mid-budget films like *Bad Newz* (July 19), a comedy with Vicky Kaushal, Ammy Virk and Triptii Dimri; *Ulajh* (August 2), a spy drama featuring Janhvi Kapoor in a lead role; and the Vikrant Massey-led *Sabarmati Report* (also Aug. 2), which looks poised to be the controversial political drama much like *The Kashmir Files* and *Kerala Story*, will vie for eyeballs. Another certainty this monsoon is that part II of *Stree*, which kicked off a whole horror comedy boom after its splendid showing in cinemas in 2018, is likely to be a safe Bollywood bet. Releasing on what will be a packed Independence Day slate with *Vedaa* (John Abraham) and *Khel Khel Mein* (Akshay Kumar again), audiences will be assured of freedom from boredom. ■